

scene bit by bit—the fireplace, the floorboards, the attire, even the material of the clothes worn by the cartoon characters is carefully chosen. “In between, I receive SMSes from team members with innovative excuses for not turning up...”, he jokes.

Oh, and as team leader, Raj has meetings to attend, called “dailies” by the insiders.

Tea and nicotine keep his system running—several smoke breaks daily.

8:00 pm sees Raj—incidentally, an avid gamer—wooing *Doom 3*, going bowling or visiting nearby pubs. “Mumbai’s a happening place!”

A college lecturer’s son, Raj has two sisters. He is popular with his nephews, although his dad insists he should come back to Dindigul and get a “proper job.” “I’ve brought several of my friends into the industry,” says Raj with a smile. Sure enough, Tamilians abound at Crest!

But all the scuttling around that a team leader needs to do has denied Raj of a dedicated workstation. “At one time I had the fastest machine in India.” You can almost see the flashback effects—“An Intel Pen-



How It’s Done: Making It Big In The Animator’s World

The Courses Involved

Basic modules in 3DS Max, Alias Maya, or Avid SoftImage XSI offered by institutes such as Arena Multimedia, Pentamedia, ZICA. Or a BA/MA in Fine/Commercial Art offered by institutes like JJ School of Arts (Mumbai), National Institute of Design (Ahmedabad) or any of the Government Arts Colleges. Or Visual Communication/Mass communication courses from places like Symbiosis (Pune), Loyola College (Chennai), Sophia Polytech, Xavier’s Institute of Communications (all Mumbai), Jamia Milia, IIMC (Delhi)

The Companies Involved

Rhythm & Hues India, Crest Communications, Toonz Animation,

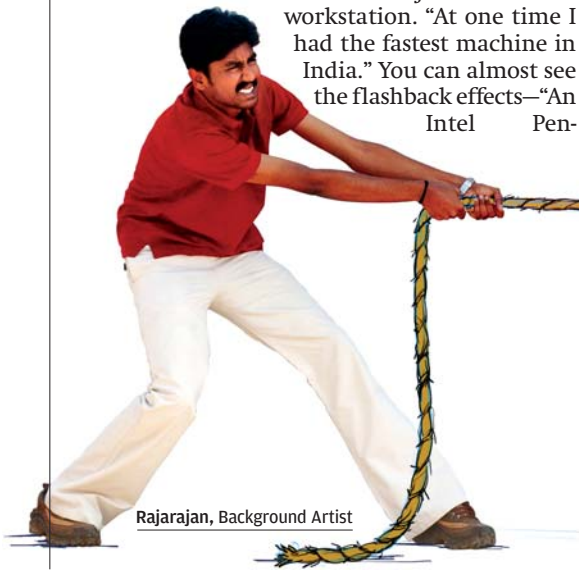
Maya Entertainment, UTV Toons, Zee Institute of Creative Arts (ZICA), 2NZ Studios, Prasad Studios, Acropetal, Padmalaya Telefilms, UTV Software Communications (UTV), Pentamedia Graphics, Jadooworks.

The Gods to Worship

Ram Mohan: One of the pioneers of animation in India, Ram Mohan is considered by many to be the “Bhishma Pitamaha” of the Indian animation industry.

Shyam Ramanna: Promoter of Crest Communications, son of late nuclear physicist Raja Ramanna, SFX and 3D guru. He is currently based in Bangkok.

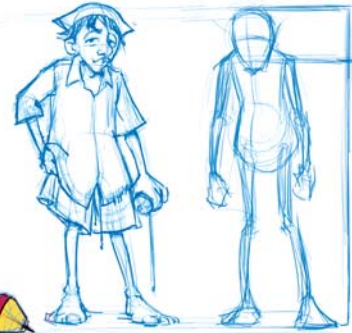
Dionysius: The Greek God of fertility and wine, often associated with insanity and inebriation!



Rajarajan, Background Artist

Art was a fascination from childhood—“I used to draw funny, animated characters and went to school half an hour early, just so I could draw them on the blackboard!”

A senior member of the Crest family,



tium4 Xeon, in a dual-processor configuration with HyperThreading, with 4 GB of RAM, and a 3DLabs Wildcat video card.” We feel his pain.

Merging It All

Once the characters and background are ready, the compositor works on merging the character with the background. Facial expressions, music and voice-overs complete the job.

“The compositor basically puts together all the layers—characters, background, shadows, lighting,” says Shilpa, who has to ensure that there is perfect harmony amongst the individual elements, while creating the final package.

Shilpa has been around for 10 years. She started out as a visualiser, handled pre-press, animation, worked as an ink and paint artiste, did 2D and is now into 3D compositing.

Shilpa’s three-year-old son Ved is her biggest fan. “My son is very excited about my work. We watch a lot of films together,” she beams.

Oh, and her days involve only work! She reaches office around 11 am—work and meetings keep her busy. “I leave around 10:30 pm and even work overnight at times. It’s a stressful career, but it’s a choice we’ve made.”

Quiz her on why there aren’t too many women around in the industry and she says: “It is a high-pressure career. My family has been